



Dynamic duo: After a carousel of coaching changes, the AIFF finally struck gold in 2025 — Crispin Chhetri took charge with Priya PV as his deputy, and together, the duo has forged a winning formula. **Below:** It was Sangita Basfore's brace in the winner-takes-all match against Thailand that capped off a journey marked by perseverance and patience. AIFF MEDIA

Planning ahead

Chhetri's first assignment was the Pink Ladies Cup in the UAE, where India faced Jordan, Russia, and South Korea. That tournament, along with his stint with Odisha FC in the AFC Women's Champions League, gave him insight into where India stood in comparison to stronger sides.

I took a younger side because I knew technically we might not be there with these teams, but physically we could be. I needed more energy on the field. Mentally, I was building a team of players which could be suitable for all kinds of matches. While I did lose some players to injury, I had the core in mind," he explains, noting the absence of seasoned internationals like Dalima Chhibber, Ashalata Devi, and Bala Devi, keeping the 2031 FIFA World Cup in mind. "I need hungry players. I need good players who make a team great, not great players who think about their names rather

than the badge. I think I took a risk [taking a young side] but the federation supported me in this, and I think now we know the result."

The 24-member squad for the qualifiers featured players like Manisha Kalyan, Grace Dangmei,

Soumya Guguloth, Elangbam Panthoi Chanu, and Kiran Pisda – all of whom brought valuable overseas club experience.

"When our players go to Europe, they play at a certain intensity which we don't get regularly in IWL. With intensity, you improve your decision-making. That helps when they come and be part of the national team and inspire others to become better."

Room for improvement

"There were no shortcuts to success – this achievement was the result of a long-term vision and structured preparation," an All India Football

Federation (AIFF) release stated, while announcing a USD 50,000 reward for the team.

The release also cited the impact of the ASMITA Leagues – a nationwide initiative launched in 2023 – which has contributed to a 232% increase in registered women footballers over the past year.

"How many people know about it?"

